

I took lessons from Vikramjit Singh and later Amit Luthra.

I remember around 100 people came to see me, and I looked at Karan and said, "You know I don't want to be here." He said the people would be there only on the first tee-box. "After that, only you, your friends and four caddies would be there. Nobody can walk with you," he said.

So I started hitting the ball and, as luck would have it, I was hitting long and hard. I guess my cricketing muscles come into play whenever I strike the ball hard. Yes, it (golf ball) used to drift right and more right, but in terms of distance it was long. And I started enjoying that.

Any particular reason why you loved the sport and continue to play even after close to three decades?

I love the game because in golf you

don't depend on anyone. You are on your own — just me and my caddie, the two of us. We decide what to do. And the target is very small, which makes it more challenging. And, if you hit a bad shot, you don't have to criticise anyone; you can only blame yourself. At some point, I felt I was born to play golf.

Did anyone say you had some special talent for golf?

I remember the first time I played with Vikramjit Singh, he noticed I had better hand-eye coordination than people with more experience. Secondly, Amit Luthra told me to keep my head down while taking a shot and not look up to see where the ball was going.

These were the two people I listened to and that's how I got deep into golf. Thereafter, I played with some pros and continued learning from them. There was a time when they would play with me by giving me a few handicap strokes. But within three to five years of playing, I was the one giving them the strokes instead. I was so over the moon. I cannot express how it felt to start playing better than the people who gave you golf lessons. That was a huge high for me.

Sometimes I feel that if I had played golf during my cricketing days, I would have ended my career with 2,000 more runs.

Why do you feel that way?

Because the level of concentration in golf is a thousand times more than in cricket. So I always tell people — once in a while play other sports as well; it will help build your mind and focus, which is very important.

In my time, my friends and teammates never played anything other than cricket. I recall Sunil Gavaskar used to play badminton sometimes, but most of the players I played with didn't pursue any other sport.

But looking back, I feel that within me I had a touch of sports. Many people can only play one game, but I

can pick up any game and it will not take much longer for me to get better at it.

Do you remember your first handicap?

I think within a year and a half I was playing to a handicap of eight. I was practising very hard. On the driving range, I wanted to hit for two hours in the morning and return to the club for another couple of hours of chipping and putting.

That was mainly because I didn't want to do anything else. I had so much spare time. Either I went for a run or exercised. So initially I spent two to four hours daily and really enjoyed it.

What kind of joy did golf bring you?

It's like flying a kite without a thread and still controlling it. I think that's what gave me a kick. I enjoyed it. I used to dream about it and I didn't mind getting up early because I was used to it due to cricket.

A lot of people who aren't good golfers don't play in the morning; they play in the afternoon.

How did you become a regular at the golf club?

I lived close to the Delhi Golf Club. During my cricketing days, my wife's grandfather filled up the membership form on my behalf. I don't remember what happened then, but when I started golf the Delhi Golf Club was kind enough to give me honorary membership. They said I didn't need to pay for being an honorary member.

But I said no — I want to pay and become a full member, which I am at present.

When did you become more ambitious as a golfer?

For two to three years, my handicap was between 10 and eight. But as time passed, it came down to two. Initially I didn't realise how it happened. But later, I noticed I had become more ambitious. Where I



THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY